

Digital Archives Reflection Assignment (2026)

Group members: MLJ, MP and IT

Part 1 - IT

Explanation of how Jensen's (2021) category of "digital archival literacy" addresses the distinct challenges digital archives represent for historical research. How has digitization changed historians' interactions with their sources? In our response, we focus on two points that we found most thought-provoking.

One of the points we find interesting in Jensen's article is her claim that: "Users need to critically assess their practices, including how digital archives target them as part of a larger audience.". We think that her claim is interesting, because it seems like historians need to add a whole new layer to their skillset to use digital sources in the right way. Jensen's point makes us think that it is important to have in mind that digital archives may not help you as a historian, rather historians need to assess and reflect upon their usage of digital archives. Another point of Jensen's that also stood out to us is her point, that "Digital archival literacy requires understanding how the production of digital archives builds on technical designs that influence their usability.". We think it is interesting that the challenge digital archives represent for historical research is that without the right competencies, historians can't find or work with digital sources to their full usability. We had not considered that there was going to be another way of working with sources digitally, and that we, as "historians", have to develop proficiency in understanding the systems that contain the sources to work with them successfully. From our perspective it seems like digital archival literacy is key, if you want to work with digital sources correctly, and that it complements the critical method historians already use in their work, just in an online context.

Part 2 - MLJ

We navigated to <https://iit.aviaryplatform.com/collections/231> and selected one of David Boder's interviews to analyze.

We will provide the biographical details of the interviewee and discuss the provenance of the source. For example, what metadata the archive provides, and which historical details the archive chooses to emphasize on in their written summary of the recording:

We have chosen the interview with David Boder Interviews Abraham Schrameck, August 21, 1946, Paris, France. Schrameck was a French Jewish man who lived from 1867-1948. He was a governmental administrator and political figure under the French Third Republic (1871-1940). During his career he held several important roles, for example he was secretary general of the prefecture of Marseille, both a Senate member and member of the upper chamber of the Third Republic's National Assembly, and minister of the interior, meaning he was head of the national police. When the second world war came Schrameck was in his 70ies and because of his career and Jewish descent he was in danger. But luckily, he survived the war with the help from friends and acquaintances. In 1948 the 19th of October, he died in Marseille. Two years before this he was interviewed in Paris.

The metadata the archive gives is the date, place, the primary and secondary language of the interview, the name, gender and nationality of the interviewee. The creator is David Boder and the keeper of the interview is the Illinois Institute of Technologies. Other metadata is the format: a wire-recording and that it's oral-history. The archive provides technical metadata like file size, type and duration. It provides subjects as "holocaust", "Jewish (1939-1945)" and "personal narratives". In an abstract and commentary, the archive chose to emphasize Schrameck's career and facts about the Jewish people in France. Also, that the Kahn-family were a part of the French Jews who had deep roots in France and were not recent immigrants.

Based on a close listening of our chosen interview, we will now contemplate how such digitized interviews might provide information absent from text-based interview transcriptions. Then we will reflect on what the implications of using interview recordings as a historical source are.

This kind of digitalized interviews can give another perspective and a deeper understanding of history. We get a sense of the interviewees state of mind under the interview and if there were to be a change in emotion and tone during the interview. This is not possible in text-based interview transcriptions because we do not know if the interviewee talks in a happy, sad, depressed, scared, light etc. tone or takes a pause. In that way we risk misinterpreting history. The interview with Schrameck begins with small talk and little laughter until Schrameck in a slow pace and calm tone begins with talking about his career. He is not crying or angry nor happy.

A downside of interviews is that the archiver still can choose what he wants to cut out of the recording and what he keeps, but that is also a possibility in a text-based interview. The implications of using interview recordings as a historical source are that we extract more reliable information because it offers emotions and a firsthand experience of the interviewee more than a text-based transcription does. Research also speaks of this absence

in text-based transcription. Some of the advantages we mentioned above that an interview as historical source has, is what Todd Presner points out in *Technologies of Testimony and Distant Witnessing*. He mentions the absence of tone in voice, pauses and emotional expression. These features can significantly shape how we interpret the meaning of what is being said, and it can provide information which deepens our understanding of history.

Part 3 - MP

We will now compare the use of digitized historical sources in web-based databases with reborn digital sources in the archived Web. We will reflect on if these sources should be treated differently when conducting historical research? We will draw on Brügger and on our knowledge of at least two database collections we discussed in class and/or your readings.

There is an underlying difference in digitized historical sources and reborn digital sources in the archived web that we must understand before we can discuss the question of how sources should be treated when conducting historical research. Digitized historical sources are historical sources that are scanned and digitized, this can be a newspaper article, or it can be a photo of a person. Digitized Historical sources are therefore analog items that are made digitally available. The reborn digital sources are digitally created, an email or a web page for example. They are therefore not analog, or scanned into an archive, maybe they are the archive, like a web page.

The two set a clear contrast between each other in their origin, one is analog, and one is born digitally. Another contrast is their relationship to their origins. A digitized historical source holds a close relationship to their original analog self, whereas a reborn digital source is one of a kind to their original self. Challenges arise when dealing with these two types of historical sources. One is a direct copy of an original, while the other is a digitally born, and altered when placed in a digital archive, as described by Niels Brügger in "DIGITAL HISTORIE OG ARKIVERET WEB SOM HISTORISK KILDE. *Temp - Tidsskrift for Historie*, 7 (14) " an example of this would be an email archive where the emails are born digitally, and stored digitally

We will now look at the question of should these two different kinds of sources be treated differently when conducting historical research, let's begin with digitized historical sources. Digitized historical sources, as explained, are scanned and made digitally available copies of an analog source. They are the closest you can get

to the original historical source if the analog source is not available. How we use these digitized historical sources is the main point of interest and debated by various people. If we look at a web page called "SalveVoyages" we can see an animated route of the slave trade, and read in to historical digitized data, however you have to think about how you treat them, like Jessica Johnson says in her text " Markup Bodies: Black [Life] Studies and Slavery [Death] Studies at the Digital Crossroads " Here she explains how the slave trade website, degrades the victims to what they were back then, a number on a manifest, and in contrast you have another website called "memomap" and interactive map of Prague that looks at the jewish population during WW2, complete with loads of individual story, when possible, would meet Jessica Johnsons criteria .

Now let's look at the reborn digital sources, as explained they are digitally born sources, that have been altered when placed into a digital archive, now when you think of that you would always question its authenticity, and its credibility, which is understandable, as historians often have to navigate a minefield of sources with varying credibility and authenticity, so can we even use the reborn digital sources? i would say yes, as it depends on the source origin, is it a screenshot of a movie? or is it an AI generated picture?

Now to sum up, should these sources be treated differently when conducting historical research? Yes, they should, but with some overlap. They both need to be looked at with source critical eyes, however Reborn digital archives need to be looked at extra carefully, they are longer away from their origins than the digitized archives. We need to have a clear background of the data we use, and judge how we use it, as explained before.